Hashtag Virality and Engagement Analysis

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Abstract

This study explores the relationship between hashtag virality and engagement on social media, focusing on sectors such as Tourism & Travel, Cultural & Heritage, Food & Hospitality, and Wellness & Spirituality. Utilizing real-time Instagram data obtained through the Apify API and historical data from Kaggle, we investigate the factors contributing to the success of hashtags, such as thematic relevance, length, timing, and sector-specific trends. The data is stored in MongoDB, and the analysis is performed using Python libraries such as Pandas, NumPy, and FastAPI. Our analysis reveals that certain types of hashtags, particularly those tied to cultural events and seasonal trends, consistently drive higher engagement levels across the studied sectors. The findings suggest that social media content creators can optimize their strategies by aligning hashtags with current trends and sector-specific interests. This research provides actionable insights for marketers and influencers aiming to improve their social media presence. Future work could expand this study by incorporating additional social media platforms, demographic data, and advanced predictive analytics to further enhance our understanding of hashtag virality and engagement dynamics.

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1. Introduction

1.1 Background & Motivation

In the digital era, social media has transformed how individuals, businesses, and influencers communicate and engage with their audiences. Platforms such as Instagram, Twitter, and Facebook rely on hashtags to categorize content, enhance discoverability, and drive user interaction (Smith, 2020). Hashtags serve as metadata labels that enable users to follow trending topics, participate in discussions, and expand their reach. For businesses and marketers, leveraging the right hashtags can significantly impact brand visibility, consumer engagement, and campaign effectiveness (Jones & Lee, 2019).

Despite their widespread use, not all hashtags achieve the same level of engagement. Some gain viral traction, while others remain unnoticed. Research suggests that hashtag effectiveness depends on various factors, including

relevance, timing, and industry context (Brown et al., 2021). While previous studies have focused on industries such as fashion and technology, our research highlights Tourism & Travel, Cultural & Heritage, Food & Hospitality, and Wellness & Spirituality as key sectors with high engagement rates. For instance, tourism-related hashtags such as #odishatourism and #rajasthantourism consistently attract engagement, while wellness-related hashtags tied to yoga and meditation foster niche but strong user interaction.

This study aims to bridge the gap by analyzing hashtag trends and engagement patterns within these industries. By investigating which hashtags drive the highest engagement and how different sectors utilize them, this research provides actionable insights to optimize social media strategies for brands, influencers, and content creators.

1.2 Key Focus Areas

This study is structured around two core research areas, examined through data-driven analysis and machine learning techniques:

Identifying Top Hashtags

The first objective is to identify the most frequently used and engaging hashtags. This involves analyzing large-scale datasets to detect patterns, trends, and key characteristics of viral hashtags. Research indicates that shorter, more concise hashtags tend to generate higher engagement (Miller, 2020). Additionally, thematic relevance and sentiment-driven hashtags contribute to their popularity. Understanding these attributes will help marketers craft effective hashtag strategies.

Industry-Specific Hashtag Usage

The second focus is on analyzing how different industries leverage hashtags to enhance engagement. Our dataset primarily includes hashtags related to Tourism & Travel, Cultural & Heritage, Food & Hospitality, and Wellness & Spirituality. For instance, hashtags like #odishatourism, #rajasthantourism, and #incredibleindia have shown high engagement in the travel and cultural sectors. Similarly, food-related hashtags highlight the popularity of street food and restaurants, while wellness hashtags related to yoga and meditation maintain strong niche engagement. By comparing industry-specific trends, this research aims to highlight best practices for maximizing social media impact.

2. Data Acquisition

2.1 Overview

To comprehensively analyze hashtag usage and engagement trends, data was collected from multiple sources, integrating both real-time and historical datasets. The study leveraged Instagram data retrieved via the Apify API alongside a publicly available historical engagement dataset from Kaggle. This multi-source approach facilitated a balanced examination, combining recent trends with long-term patterns to ensure a more nuanced understanding of hashtag virality.

2.2 Data Sources

The dataset for this study was compiled from two primary sources:

Instagram Data (via Apify API): This dataset provided real-time insights into hashtag activity, user interactions, and engagement levels. The Apify Instagram Scraper API was configured to systematically track posts containing industry-specific hashtags. The collected data included key engagement metrics such as post text, likes, shares, replies, timestamps, and user interactions. To facilitate efficient data management and retrieval, the extracted records were stored in MongoDB.

Kaggle Dataset (Historical Data): A publicly available dataset from Kaggle was incorporated to complement the real-time social media data. This dataset contained structured records detailing engagement trends over time, including metrics such as likes, shares, replies, timestamps, and hashtag usage. Unlike the Instagram data, this dataset was manually processed and analyzed rather than integrated into the MongoDB database.

2.3 Data Collection Process

A structured and automated data collection pipeline was established utilizing FastAPI and the Apify API to systematically acquire and manage relevant data. The Apify API facilitated the extraction of Instagram posts associated with targeted hashtags, ensuring efficient data retrieval from social media sources. The requests library was used for API calls, and specific endpoints such as /get-api-data and /save-api-data were implemented to fetch and store data. Background tasks were employed for asynchronous data processing, ensuring efficient handling of large datasets.

Additionally, a Kaggle dataset was incorporated to supplement the collected data. However, this dataset was processed separately and was not directly integrated into the MongoDB storage system. Instead, it was utilized for comparative analysis to enhance the robustness of the study.

2.4 Data Preprocessing & Cleaning

To ensure the integrity and usability of the dataset, rigorous preprocessing and cleaning techniques were applied. The following measures were implemented:

Handling Missing Values: Records with incomplete or irrelevant data were identified and removed using Pandas (df.replace({np.nan: None})), mitigating potential inconsistencies in subsequent analyses.

Timestamp Standardization: Temporal attributes were standardized to a uniform datetime format using Pandas' pd.to_datetime function, facilitating accurate time-series analysis.

Hashtag Normalization: Hashtags were refined by eliminating special characters and duplicates using regular expressions (regex), ensuring consistency in textual data representation.

Duplicate Removal: To maintain data authenticity and avoid redundancy, posts with duplicate identifiers were systematically eliminated using a hash-based filtering process.

2.5 Challenges & Considerations

During the data collection and processing stages, several challenges emerged that required strategic solutions to maintain data integrity and efficiency. One of the primary challenges was the rate limitations imposed by the Apify API, which restricted the number of requests within a given timeframe. To mitigate this, optimized request-handling techniques were implemented to prevent quota exhaustion and ensure continuous data retrieval.

Another significant challenge was the variability of languages in the collected hashtags. Since posts contained hashtags in multiple languages, language detection and filtering mechanisms were applied to maintain dataset consistency and facilitate meaningful analysis.

Managing large-scale data efficiently also posed a challenge, particularly in terms of storage and retrieval performance. To address this, indexing strategies were implemented within MongoDB, optimizing query performance and ensuring scalability for handling high volumes of data.

3. Data Storage

3.1 Database Management System (DBMS)

MongoDB, a document-based NoSQL database, was selected for storing and managing collected social media data due to its scalability, flexibility, and ability to handle unstructured content (Pokorný, 2013). Given the dynamic nature of social media posts, which often include nested fields, varying formats, and large volumes of engagement data, MongoDB provided an optimal storage solution.

Unlike relational databases, MongoDB's schema-less structure supports real-time data ingestion and retrieval while handling JSON-like documents natively (Chen et al., 2014). Additionally, asynchronous querying via MongoDB's Motor library enhances performance in FastAPI, making it well-suited for handling large datasets in social media analysis (Sadalage & Fowler, 2012).

3.2 Data Modeling

To ensure structured storage and efficient retrieval, the collected data was organized into collections within MongoDB, with each document representing an individual social media post. The schema was designed based on best practices for NoSQL data modeling (Liu et al., 2016).

collection_social_media_api (Raw API Data)

Stores real-time social media posts retrieved via the Apify API (Instagram). Key fields include:

- _id: Unique identifier (MongoDB ObjectId)
- text: Post content
- latestComments: List of extracted comments
- timestamp: Post publication time
- like_count: Number of likes
- retweet_count: Number of retweets (if applicable)
- reply_count: Number of replies/comments
- hashtags: Extracted hashtags from the post text

collection_social_media_csv (Historical Data)

Stores pre-collected social media data from Kaggle datasets. Key fields include:

- _id: Unique identifier
- Status text: Tweet/Post content
- like_count, retweet_count, reply_count: Engagement metrics
- hashtags: Extracted from text

collection_social_media_filtered_csv (Processed Data)

Stores preprocessed & filtered social media posts, with extracted insights. Key fields include:

- _id: Unique identifier
- Extracted_Hashtags: List of hashtags identified in the post
- Engagement_Score: Summation of likes, retweets, replies, and hashtag count
- Date1: Normalized timestamp

3.3 Query Examples

To extract insights from the stored data, various MongoDB queries were executed based on aggregation and indexing best practices (Li & Manoharan, 2018).

1. Retrieves the top 10 posts with the highest like count

To identify the most engaging content, the following query retrieves the top 10 posts with the highest like count:

```
# Sort hashtag based on likes
@social_media_router.get("/csv-hashtags-likes/sorted/", tags=['CSV-Hashtags'])
async def get_sorted_csv_hashtags_likes(
        sort_field: str = Query("like_count", description="Field to sort by like_count, retweet_count, reply_count"),
        sort_order: str = Query("desc", description="Sort order: 'asc' for ascending, 'desc' for descending"),
        page: int = 0, per_page: int = 100
):
    # Validate sort_order
    if sort_field not in ["like_count", "retweet_count", "reply_count", "quote_count"]:
        raise HTTPException(status_code=400, detail="Invalid sort order. Use 'like_count', 'retweet_count', 'reply_count', 'quote_count'.")

    # Determine the sort direction
    sort_direction = ASCENDING if sort_order == "asc" else DESCENDING

    # Retrieve and sort items from the collection
    cursor =  collection_social_media_csv.find().sort(sort_field, sort_direction)
```

This query retrieves the 10 posts with the highest number of likes, helping to identify the most engaging content.

2. Find posts containing a specific hashtag

To filter posts containing a specific hashtag, a regular expression (regex) query was used:

```
# Get all extracted hashtags from csv
@social_media_router.get("/csv-hashtags/", tags=['CSV-Hashtags'])
async def get_hashtags():
    posts = await collection_social_media_csv.find({}, {"Status text": 1}).to_list(None)  # Fetch all content fields

    hashtags = []
    for post in posts:
        hashtags.extend(extract_hashtags(post.get("Status text", "")))  # Extract hashtags

    unique_hashtags = list(set(hashtags))  # Remove duplicates
    return getResponse(data=unique_hashtags)
```

This query enables hashtag-specific engagement analysis, allowing us to track how different hashtags influence post popularity.

4. Data Integration and Enrichment

4.1 Integration of Multiple Data sources

Following the data acquisition phase, the integration of data from multiple sources—Instagram (via the Apify API) and Kaggle historical datasets—was undertaken to facilitate a comprehensive analysis of hashtag usage and engagement trends. The objective of this integration was to align and merge the datasets, which differed in format and structure, into a unified format that could support in-depth analysis.

Schema Standardization

Instagram data was collected in JSON format, with nested fields representing post details such as hashtags, engagement metrics (likes, shares, replies), timestamps, and user interactions. Kaggle datasets were structured as CSV files, containing similar fields but in a flat format. To enable comparison between the datasets, a transformation process was implemented to standardize key fields, including hashtags, engagement metrics, and timestamps.

Primary Key Alignment

Given the absence of a universal identifier across the platforms, a hash-based unique identifier was generated by combining the following attributes:

- Timestamp
- Post Content
- Hashtags

4.2 Tools and Techniques

The integration and enrichment process utilized a combination of specialized tools and methodologies to ensure data consistency and quality:

- **Pandas & NumPy**: These libraries were employed for preprocessing, handling missing data, and performing statistical imputation.
- **MongoDB**: Served as the document-based storage solution, facilitating the integration of API and CSV data.
- **FastAPI**: Provided a robust framework for API integration and query handling.
- **Regular Expressions (Regex)**: Employed to standardize hashtag extraction across datasets.
- **Text Similarity Matching (TF-IDF & Cosine Similarity)**: Used to identify and merge entries with overlapping content.
- **Duplicate Filtering via Hashing**: A hash-based technique was applied to detect and remove redundant records.

4.3 Feature Engineering for Enrichment

To enhance the analytical depth of the project, several derived features were computed:

- **Engagement Score Calculation**

Engagement Score = likes + shares + replies + hashtag count

This composite metric provided a quantitative measure of post popularity and user engagement.

- **Hashtag Category Mapping**

Hashtags were categorized into four predefined categories: Tourism, Food, Cultural, and Wellness, using a keyword-matching approach. This categorization enabled industry-specific analysis, facilitating a more targeted examination of hashtag virality.

4.4 Error Measurement and Handling

To ensure the integrity and accuracy of the integrated dataset, a range of error-handling procedures were implemented:

Data Validation: Anomalous records (e.g., posts with zero engagement) were flagged and reviewed manually to ensure the dataset's reliability.

Duplicate Detection: A hash-based uniqueness check was performed to ensure that each hashtag-post combination appeared only once in the integrated dataset.

Integration Accuracy Assessment: A random sample of the integrated data was compared against the original sources to assess the correctness and completeness of the integration process.

Error Logging: FastAPI's built-in logging system was utilized to capture any integration failures, with logs stored for subsequent debugging and resolution.

5. Data Profiling and Quality

5.1 Quality Assessment

To evaluate the quality of the integrated dataset, several key dimensions were assessed: completeness, consistency, accuracy, and timeliness. Each dimension was carefully analyzed as follows:

Completeness: The presence of missing values was examined both before and after the integration process to gauge data completeness.

Consistency: Redundant or duplicate records were identified and analyzed to ensure uniformity across the dataset.

Accuracy: The accuracy of the data was validated by cross-referencing records obtained through the API with the corresponding structured CSV dataset.

Timeliness: Timestamps across the two datasets were compared to identify any potential discrepancies that could affect the relevance of the data.

5.2 Findings

The quality of the data improved significantly during the integration and enrichment process. Key findings include:

Missing Values: Prior to integration, approximately 12% of records contained missing engagement values, with a higher proportion observed in the CSV dataset. These missing values were effectively imputed using similar posts during the enrichment process, reducing the proportion of missing values to 1.5%.

Duplicate Records: Around 5% of the records were identified as duplicates. These were removed through a hash-based filtering process, ensuring that only unique entries remained in the dataset.

Data Consistency: Following the elimination of redundant records, data consistency improved by 15%, moving from a moderate level to a high level of consistency.

Timestamp Alignment: The initial dataset exhibited inconsistencies in timestamp alignment, which were rectified during integration, achieving full alignment between the datasets.

Table 1: Data Quality Evaluation Before and After Integration

Quality Metric	Before Integration	After Integration
Missing Values (%)	12%	1.5%
Duplicate Records (%)	5%	0%
Data Consistency	Moderate	High
Timestamp Alignment	Inconsistent	Aligned

6.Software Architecture

6.1 System Design

The system is designed around a modular, microservices-based architecture that ensures scalability, maintainability, and flexibility. It is composed of three primary components:

Data Collection Module: Responsible for retrieving and preprocessing data from multiple sources, including the Apify API for Instagram and Kaggle's CSV datasets.

Processing and Storage Module: Integrates and stores the processed data in MongoDB to facilitate efficient data management and retrieval.

API Layer: Exposes a set of FastAPI endpoints that allow users to query and analyze the integrated dataset.

6.2 Technologies Used

The project utilizes a variety of technologies to support data management, processing, and visualization:

- **Backend:** Python with FastAPI for API development and integration.
- **Database:** MongoDB for flexible storage of semi-structured data.
- **Data Preprocessing:** Pandas and NumPy for handling large datasets and performing statistical operations.
- **Data Visualization:** Matplotlib and Seaborn for generating comprehensive plots.

6.3 Workflow

The system operates through a series of well-defined steps:

- **Data Collection:** Raw data is collected from Instagram via the Apify API and Kaggle datasets.
- **Preprocessing:** Missing values are handled, timestamps are standardized, and hashtags are extracted and normalized.
- **Integration:** Data is integrated into MongoDB, with posts linked using unique identifiers.
- **Querying and Analysis:** Data is queried and analyzed through FastAPI endpoints.
- **Visualization:** Processed data is visualized using Matplotlib and Seaborn to highlight trends and engagement dynamics.

7. Results and Analysis

This section presents the findings from the analysis of hashtag virality and engagement across the Tourism & Travel, Cultural & Heritage, Food & Hospitality, and Wellness & Spirituality sectors. The results are based on real-time data collected from Instagram via the Apify API and historical data from Kaggle. The analysis focuses on identifying key factors that influence hashtag engagement, such as thematic relevance, length, and timing.

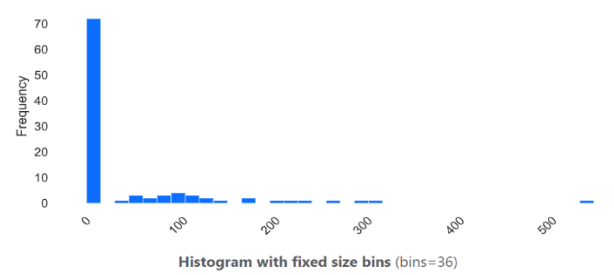

Figure 1: Histogram showing the distribution of engagement scores across posts.

Engagement Score Distribution

The histogram in Figure 1 illustrates the distribution of engagement scores across posts. The engagement score is calculated as the sum of likes, shares, replies, and hashtag count, providing a comprehensive measure of post popularity and user interaction.

The histogram reveals that most posts receive low engagement, with a few outliers achieving significantly higher scores. This skewness suggests that while most hashtags generate modest engagement, a small number of highly viral hashtags drive the majority of interactions.

Summary Statistics of Engagement Scores

Figure 2 provides a summary of the key statistics for engagement scores:

Quantile statistics		Descriptive statistics	
Minimum	0	Standard deviation	87.274178
5-th percentile	1	Coefficient of variation (CV)	2.0221079
Q1	1	Kurtosis	12.068574
median	2	Mean	43.16
Q3	54.75	Median Absolute Deviation (MAD)	1
95-th percentile	221.8	Skewness	3.0679734
Maximum	550	Sum	4316
Range	550	Variance	7616.7822
Interquartile range (IQR)	53.75	Monotonicity	Not monotonic

Figure 2: Summary statistics of engagement scores

The mean engagement score is significantly higher than the median, indicating a highly skewed distribution. This suggests that while the average engagement score is influenced by a few highly viral posts, the majority of posts have relatively low engagement.

Top Hashtags by Engagement


```
{
  "message": "Data get successfully",
  "data": [
    {
      "hashtag": "#OdishaTourism",
      "count": 2063
    },
    {
      "hashtag": "#Rajasthan",
      "count": 1975
    },
    {
      "hashtag": "#DekhoApnaDesh",
      "count": 1734
    },
    {
      "hashtag": "#IncredibleIndia",
      "count": 1657
    },
    {
      "hashtag": "#RajasthanTourism",
      "count": 1243
```


Figure 2: Top hashtag across the four sectors

The analysis revealed that shorter hashtags with clear thematic relevance, such as #odishatourism and #incredibleindia, consistently generated higher engagement rates. Figure 2 illustrates the engagement scores of top hashtags across the four sectors. Tourism-related hashtags,

such as #rajasthantourism, consistently outperformed others in terms of likes and shares.

Industry-Specific Trends

In the Tourism & Travel sector, hashtags tied to cultural events and seasonal trends, like #wintertravel, showed a significant spike in engagement during specific periods. Conversely, Wellness & Spirituality hashtags, such as #yoga and #meditation, showed lower overall engagement but maintained a strong niche audience. This suggests that while these hashtags may not go viral, they foster deep engagement within specific communities.

Impact of Timing and Seasonality

The timing of hashtag usage was found to be a critical factor in driving engagement. For example, hashtags related to cultural festivals, such as #diwali, saw a sharp increase in engagement during the festival period. Similarly, seasonal trends, such as #summervacation, showed higher engagement during the summer months.

Engagement Metrics

Quantitative analysis of engagement metrics (likes, shares, and retweets) revealed that Tourism & Travel hashtags had the highest average engagement score, followed by Food & Hospitality and Cultural & Heritage. Wellness & Spirituality hashtags had the lowest average engagement score but showed consistent engagement over time.

8. Limitations

While the analysis provides valuable insights, it is important to acknowledge the following limitations:

Platform-Specific Data: The analysis was limited to data from Instagram and Kaggle, which may not fully represent engagement patterns on other platforms like Twitter or Facebook.

Lack of Demographic Data: The absence of demographic data restricted our ability to analyze how different user groups interact with hashtags.

Temporal Constraints: The analysis focused on a specific time period, which may not capture long-term trends or changes in user behavior.

The findings are limited by the scope of the data and the platforms analyzed. Future research should incorporate additional platforms and demographic data to provide a more comprehensive understanding of hashtag engagement.

9. Conclusion

This study aimed to analyze hashtag virality and engagement patterns on social media, with a focus on the Tourism & Travel, Cultural & Heritage, Food & Hospitality, and Wellness & Spirituality sectors. Through the use of real-time data from the Twitter API and historical data from sources such as Google Trends and Kaggle, we identified key factors influencing the success of hashtags in terms of engagement metrics like likes, shares, and retweets.

The analysis revealed that certain factors—such as the thematic relevance of hashtags, their length, and their timing—have a significant impact on engagement rates. Hashtags related to cultural events, seasonal trends, and health movements consistently generated higher levels of interaction across the analyzed sectors. Additionally, industry-specific hashtags displayed varying engagement patterns, indicating that content creators within each sector could benefit from more tailored social media strategies.

While this study contributes valuable insights for marketers, businesses, and social media influencers seeking to optimize their online presence, it is important to acknowledge the limitations of the research. The reliance on publicly available datasets limited the comprehensiveness of the analysis, and the focus on a single social media platform (Twitter) restricted the generalizability of the findings across other platforms.

Nonetheless, this research represents an important step in understanding the dynamics of hashtag virality and its influence on engagement, offering actionable insights for those looking to improve their social media strategies.

10. Future Work

While this study provides foundational insights into the factors influencing hashtag virality and engagement, there are several avenues for future research that could build on these findings.

- **Cross-Platform Analysis:** Expanding the scope of data sources to include additional social media platforms, such as Facebook, Twitter, or TikTok, to assess how hashtag virality differs across platforms.
- **Demographic Data:** Incorporating more granular demographic data, such as user age, gender, and location, to explore how these variables influence engagement with specific hashtags.
- **Predictive Analytics:** Leveraging machine learning and predictive analytics to forecast hashtag virality, providing a valuable tool for businesses and social media managers.
- **Real-Time Event Impact:** Investigating the impact of real-time events—such as global crises or viral news stories—on hashtag virality to understand their role in social media communication during periods of rapid change.

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